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GOTHAM**Gotham took over the world**Explore how the Gotham typeface became popular over the years,
<https://digit.in/may19-63>**The Color Dot font**The Color Dot font communicates with the language of colour.
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The evolution of typefaces is a lesson in human history

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ou're reading this sentence on a piece of paper. Or maybe a digitised version of this article on a

screen. In either case, you're directly interacting with the typeface that this article is printed or published in. Typefaces have been around for as long as the printed letter. Prior to printing, all books and written media was created by hand and hence their visual representation varied based on the writer/copier. However, printing merely led to the creation of the typeface but does not explain why there are so many out there.

There are reasons behind it that are deeply linked with human history. However, first, you need to understand the difference between a typeface and a font.

TYPEFACE VS FONT

To understand the difference between the two, it is important to dip briefly into the history of how the printed letter was... well, printed. Printers used to have big blocks with metal letters cut into them that would be dipped into ink and pressed onto the paper in order to print. Each character that had to be printed had a bunch of metal blocks representing the typeface. Now, each typeface used to have multiple blocks within it, each with different sized characters (10 point, 12 point, 14 point) and varying weights (bold, light, medium). A block with a particular size and weight would represent a font. All of the fonts together would form what was called the typeface.

As an updated example, consider that this article is being typed out in Google Docs using Arial Regular 11. That's the Arial typeface, choosing the 11 point size, with the 'Regular' font. So here Arial Regular 11 is a font, while Arial is a typeface. Arial Bold 11 is a different font from the same Arial typeface, as is Arial Regular 10. If you're reading this in the magazine, then you're reading it in the Farnham Display 8.75 font. That's a part of the Farnham typeface. Essentially, you can never use just a typeface, you'll always be using a specific font. Now you can correct your friends when they say "the font is Arial", by telling them "The *typeface* is Arial. The font might be Arial Narrow 11".

THE EVOLUTION

One of the oldest typefaces, the Blackletter, emerged in the middle ages and stuck around well into the 17th century, especially if you look at the history of printing in Germany. It has descended from the Carolingian minuscule script, which itself was developed in about 780 AD. As books started to grow in popularity, scribes needed a typeface that was easier to use and could fit more words into a page. The tall, narrow, sharp and blocky Blackletter emerged as a solution. You might know Blackletter today by the more modern nomenclature of Gothic.

When the humanist movement began in Italy in the 1400s, the humanist thinkers found the stateliness of the Gothic typefaces to be out of touch with the spirit of humanism. They were looking for something more approachable, more readable and lighter on the eyes. When the printers Konrad Sweynheim and Arnold Pannartz in Subiaco, Italy, brought out an edition of Cicero in 1465, they used a typeface that was distinguished from the Gothic, that was more "modern" in the 15th century, by calling it Antiqua. Known today as Roman, it spread rapidly throughout western Europe except in Germany, where the